

MEN IN CHARGE Telangana chief minister A. Revanth Reddy with Deputy CM Mallu Bhatti Vikramarka

A. REVANTH REDDY, 54

PERSONAL BACKGROUND Born in a farmer's family in Kalwakurthy, Mahbubnagar district

EDUCATION: Graduate in fine arts from AV College, Hyderabad

FAMILY: Married Geetha in 1992, has a daughter

POLITICAL TRAINING: Started with ABVP; two-time TDP MLA from Kodangal (2009-19); Congress MP from Malkajgiri in 2019

POSTS HELD: Made TDP Telangana chief in 2014; appointed state Congress chief in 2021

WORK STYLE: Passionate and driven, he is also a patient listener, takes everyone on board

'BRIGHT AND RADIANT'

The most striking thing about Revanth ('bright and radiant' in Sanskrit) Reddy is his meteoric rise. The 54-year-old joined the Congress in December 2017 and was appointed Telangana Pradesh Congress Committee (TPCC) chief in July 2021. That he has become the chief minister without any earlier experience in governance—a newbie's phenomenal progress in the Grand Old Party in six years—is a brilliant achievement. Behind it is Reddy's capacity for hard work and the ability to inspire and lead party workers. Along with tactical nous, Reddy has shown remarkable maturity too. Inasmuch as the Congress castigated the BRS on various counts and Reddy himself took the fight to KCR during the poll campaign, the heat of the battlefield was set aside once results were announced. On December 10, he called on KCR, who is recovering from a hip transplant, at Hyderabad's Yashoda Hospital—a gesture that garnered wide appreciation. Reddy is also known to be a patient listener of seniors' opinions despite having differing views, and takes everyone in the party on board.

REDDY SHOWED MATURITY IN SETTING POLL BITTERNESS ASIDE AND VISITING KCR IN HOSPITAL. IT WAS WIDELY APPRECIATED

"Young and aspirational, Revanth's weakness may be his lack of experience as a minister. But he is smart enough to catch up," observes Harathi Vageeshan, who teaches politics at the NALSAR University. "He is taking every step cautiously and wisely, without haste. His choice of the team is also well-directed."

It is still early days, but Reddy, say some experts, reminds them of Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy (YSR). The former Andhra Pradesh CM and Congress heavyweight, too, was a methodical worker and a natural leader of men. "Through his career, Reddy has served as the voice of the voiceless and is capable of delivering under any circumstance. This is because he knows the pulse of the people," says Congress leader Mallu Ravi, a former two-term MP and MLA and TPCC vice president.

YSR had sensed Reddy's potential and invited him to join the Congress after he beat the party's candidate as an independent contestant in the Legislative Council elections in 2007. This was after he spent three years, 2002-2005, in the Telangana Rashtra Samithi (TRS). Instead, Reddy joined Chandrababu Naidu's Telugu Desam Party (TDP). He was a two-term TDP MLA from Kodangal in 2009 and 2014. KCR-Revanth Reddy relations nosedived in 2015 when the Anti-Corruption Bureau implicated him in a cash-for-votes case. His appeal to close the case comes up in the Supreme Court on January 5, 2024.

While sceptics wrote his political epitaph after the scandal, Reddy vowed to teach KCR a lesson in the future. As the Congress candidate for the Kodangal assembly seat in 2018, Reddy lost. But the setback did not deter him and, six months later, he won the Malkajgiri seat in the 2019 LS polls. After impressing fellow Congressmen with his streetfighting ways, being anointed the Telangana Congress chief was a natural progression. "Some are apprehensive of him handling emerging situations. Revanth Reddy of yesterday is different today and will not be the same tomorrow. The metamorphosis from zilla parishad member to CM shows how he copes with challenges," says Ravi.

Infrastructure development in a cost-effective manner is what interests Reddy most. This is why instead of laying the earlier sanctioned greenfield metro line through unpopulated areas from the Rajiv Gandhi Airport to western Hyderabad, the CM wants it to go through the populated southern parts of the city, so that it can benefit people and earn profit. Reddy's immediate concern, however, is the efficient delivery of the many guarantee schemes. Poor delivery of welfare schemes was a big factor in the anti-incumbency that unseated the BRS, and Reddy is expected to reorganise the upper echelons of administration to implement his plans in the shortest possible time. ■